AIKO SCHMEISSER

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CURRENT POSITION

Center for Political Economy, Columbia University 2025 - 2026
Postdoctoral Research Scholar

RESEARCH FIELDS

Labor Economics, Political Economy, Behavioral Economics

EDUCATION

University of Potsdam & Berlin School of Economics 2020 - 2025
Ph.D. in Economics
Supervisor: Marco Caliendo, Thomas Siedler
Title of dissertation: Political and Racial Dynamics in the Labor Market

Harvard University Jan - May, 2024
Visiting research fellow at the Center for Labor and a Just Economy

University of Göttingen 2018 - 2020
M.Sc. in International Economics

University of Bayreuth 2014 - 2018
B.Sc. in Economics, B.A. in International Economics and Development

WORKING PAPERS

Do Unions Shape Political Ideologies at Work? (with Johannes Matzat), CESifo Working Paper No. 10301. *R&R American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* [latest version]

Labor unions influence economic outcomes not only through bargaining with employers over work contracts but also via political activities that can profoundly shape political systems. In unionized workplaces, they may mobilize and change the ideological positions of both unionizing workers and their non-unionizing management. In this paper, we analyze the workplace-level impact of unionization on workers' and managers' political campaign contributions. We link establishment-level union election data with transaction-level campaign contributions to federal and local candidates in the United States. Using a difference-in-differences design, validated through regression discontinuity tests and a novel instrumental variable approach, we find that unionization leads to a leftward shift of campaign contributions. Unionization increases support for Democrats relative to Republicans not only among workers but especially among managers, suggesting that managers converge toward workers' political preferences. The effects are stronger in settings with more cooperative union-employer interactions, such as when union elections are not contested by an unfair labor practice charge and result in a collective bargaining agreement.

The Accuracy of Job Seekers' Wage Expectations (with Marco Caliendo, Robert Mahlstedt, and Sophie Wagner), IZA Discussion Paper No. 17198. *R&R Journal of Public Economics* [link]

We study the accuracy of job seekers' wage expectations by comparing subjective beliefs to objective benchmarks using linked administrative and survey data. Our findings show that especially job seekers with low objective earnings potential and those predicted to face a penalty compared to their pre-unemployment wage display overly optimistic wage expectations. Moreover, wage optimism is amplified by increased job search incentives and job seekers with overoptimistic wage expectations tend to overestimate their reemployment chances. We discuss the labor market implications of wage optimism, as well as the role of information frictions and motivated beliefs as sources of overoptimism.

Economic Shocks, Opportunity Costs, and the Supply of Politicians (with Laura Barros), CESifo Working Paper No. 12327. *Submitted* [link]

Adverse economic shocks are known to reshape voter behavior – the demand side of politics. Much less is known about their consequences for the supply side: how such shocks affect who becomes a politician. This paper examines how job losses influence individuals' decisions to enter politics and the implications for political selection. Using administrative data linking political participation records to matched employer-employee data covering all formal workers in Brazil, and exploiting mass layoffs for causal identification, we find that job loss significantly increases the likelihood of joining a political party and running for local office. Layoff-induced candidates are positively selected on various competence measures, indicating that economic shocks can improve the quality of political entrants. The increase in candidacies is strongest among laid-off individuals with greater financial incentives from holding office and higher predicted income losses. A regression discontinuity design further shows that eligibility for unemployment benefits increases political entry. These results are consistent with a reduction in individuals' opportunity costs – both in terms of reduced private-sector income and increased time resources – facilitating greater political engagement.

Racial Peer Effects at Work: Evidence from Worker Deaths in Brazil (with Katharina Fietz). World Bank Policy Research Working Paper No. 10899. [link]

This paper studies the impact of working with same-race coworkers on individuals' retention at firms. Using administrative employer-employee data from Brazil, the paper exploits unexpected deaths of workers from different racial groups as exogenous shocks to peer group composition. The findings show that a decrease in the non-white share of coworkers reduces the retention of non-white workers but does not affect the retention of white workers. The effects are driven by non-whites quitting and moving to new jobs with more peers of the same race than in their old jobs. The findings highlight how peer dynamics can contribute to racial segregation across workplaces.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Shades of Disparity: Race Perceptions and Labor Market Outcomes in Brazil (with Pedro C. Sant'Anna and Sulin Sardoschau)

The Value of Peers: Coworker Preferences in a Job Choice Experiment

PUBLICATIONS (PRE-PHD)

A Tale of (Almost) 1001 Coefficients: Deep and Heterogeneous Effects of the EU-Turkey Customs Union (with Mario Larch and Joschka Wanner), 2021, ***Journal of Common Market Studies***, 59(2), 242-260. [link]

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Conference and Seminar Presentations

Political Economy of Work Junior Scholars Workshop (Columbia U), European Economic Association (Bordeaux), CESifo Junior Workshop on Labor Economics (Munich), Workshop on the Economics of Identity (Berlin), Research Seminar in Economics (Potsdam)	2025, incl. scheduled
Verein für Socialpolitik (Berlin), IZA Summer School (Bonn), Society of Labor Economists (Portland), European Economic Association (Rotterdam), Economics PhD Conference (Warwick), RIDGE / LACEA Workshops on Labor & Political Economy (Santiago de Chile), European Society for Population Economics (Rotterdam), Midwest Political Science Association (Chicago), Political Economy Workshop (Harvard U), Rockwool Foundation Graduate Seminar (Berlin), BSoE Applied Micro & Behavioral Economics Workshop (Berlin), BeNA Winter Workshop (Berlin), Applied Young Economist Webinar (online)	2024
European Association of Labor Economics (Prague), European Economic Association (Barcelona), Society for Institutional & Organizational Economics (Frankfurt), European Society for Population Economics (Belgrade), IAAEU Colloquium on Economics (Trier), Research Seminar in Economics (Potsdam)	2023
ifo Workshop on Political Economy (Dresden), Verein für Socialpolitik (Basel), European Association of Labor Economics (Padua), European Society for Population Economics (Calabria), FU Research Seminar for Applied Micro (Berlin), BeNA Winter Workshop (Berlin), BSoE Summer Workshop (Berlin)	2022
European Association of Labor Economics (online), European Society for Population Economics (online)	2021

Services to the Profession

Referee for *Quarterly Journal of Economics, Labour Economics, Empirical Economics*

Board member and treasurer of the Berlin Network of Labor Market Research (BeNA) [link] 2024 -

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

Joachim Herz Add-on Fellowship for Interdisciplinary Economics and Interdisciplinary Business Administration, 12,500 Euro 2023 - 2025

DAAD Research Stay Grant for Doctoral Students, 4,600 Euro 2024

DAAD Conference Travel Grant, 1,000 Euro 2024

Wicksell Prize of the European Public Choice Society, 2nd place for the research paper "Do Unions Shape Political Ideologies at Work?" 2023

Student scholarship Konrad Adenauer Foundation 2015 - 2018

TEACHING

University of Potsdam

Advanced Microeconometrics (practical session, graduate level)	Winter 2021/22, 2022/23, 2023/24
Policy Evaluation (practical session, graduate level)	Summer 2023
Research Idea Development Seminar (seminar, graduate level)	Winter 2021/22, 2023/24
Advanced Methods and Applications in Policy Evaluation (seminar, graduate level)	Winter 2022/23
Methods in Policy Evaluation (seminar, undergraduate level)	Summer 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025
Statistics (practical session, undergraduate level)	Summer 2022
Supervision of final theses (7× undergraduate and 4× graduate level)	Winter 2021/22 - Summer 2025

University of Bayreuth

Macroeconomics I (practical session, undergraduate level)	Summer 2016, 2017
Microeconomics I (practical session, undergraduate level)	Winter 2015/16

WORK EXPERIENCE

University of Potsdam 2021 - 2025
Research Assistant at the Chair of Empirical Economics

University of Göttingen 2018 - 2020
Student Research Assistant at the Research Training Group Globalization and Development
Fieldwork Assistant for RCT in Cambodia

German Council of Economic Experts 2018
Internship at Labor Market Team of Scientific Staff

University of Bayreuth 2017 - 2018
Student Research Assistant at Chair of Development Economics

German Ministry for Economic Affairs and Energy 2017
Internship at Department for Trade Policy with North America